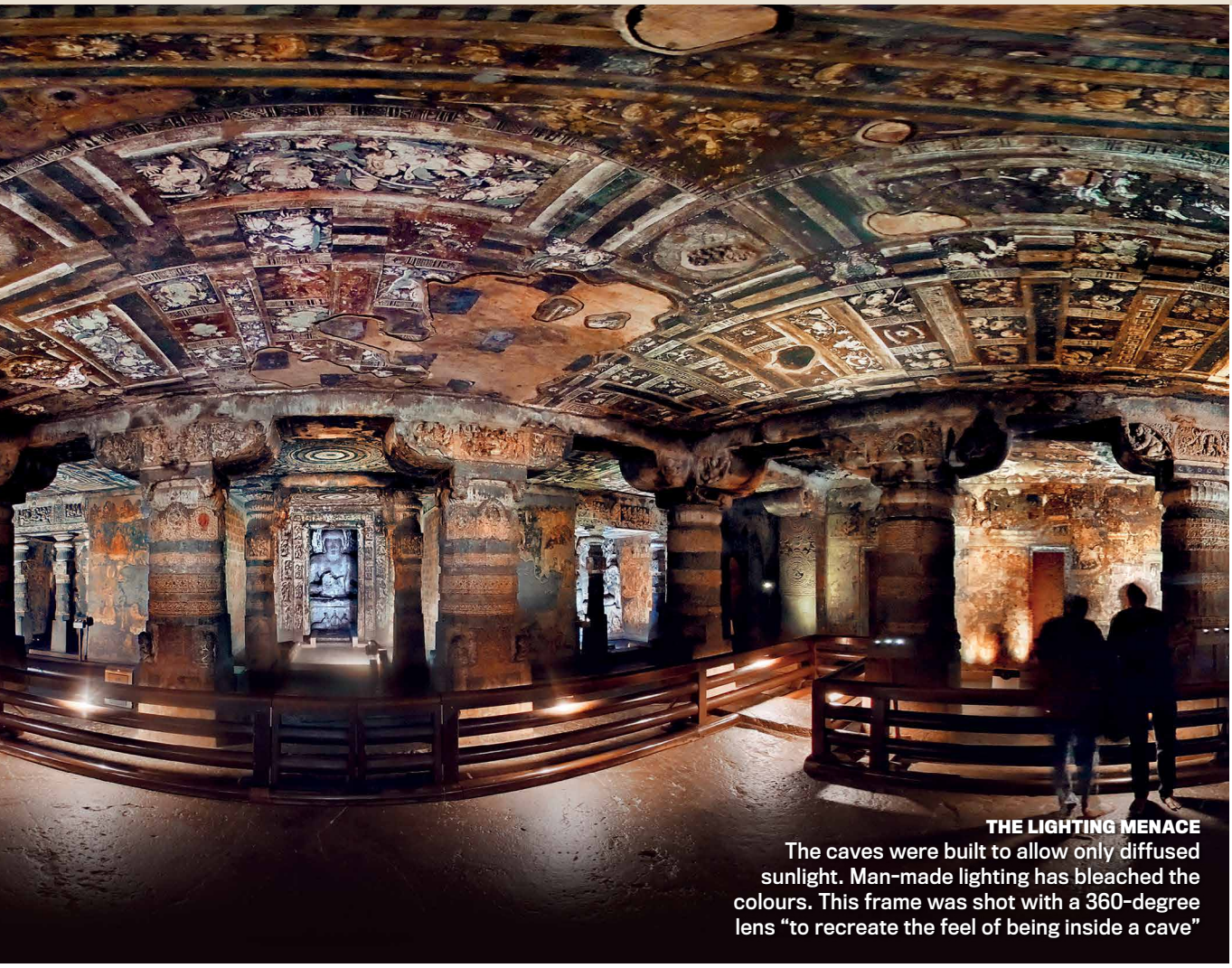


THE LIGHTING MENACE
The caves were built to allow only diffused sunlight. Man-made lighting has bleached the colours. This frame was shot with a 360-degree lens "to recreate the feel of being inside a cave"

Ajanta circa 480 AD, during the long eclipse that set in sometime after Hiuen Tsang spoke of it in the seventh century, nature took over from culture again. Microbes and insects found food in the richly organic plaster. Silverfish, especially, dug holes in it and feasted on the vegetal-origin cellulose fibre and the animal protein in the binder. Their own unseen mass burials inside the plaster set up an unending banquet for others. "Over one millennium, they destroyed a quarter of Ajanta's murals," says Manager Singh. They continue to do so, as fumigation in 2021 revealed: the microclimate, as NEERI studies found, is simply too hospitable for insect larvae, pupae and a galaxy of bacteria, algae, fungi and higher life. As the silverfish came out at night during all those centuries, they were fed upon by a whole chain of insects that in turn fed the other caped nobility that rules caves: bats. The doors have been slammed shut on them now, but one millennium of acidic bat excreta deposition, with slowly decomposing urea, still plays its grim hand. Those spooky beings, the unknown wonders of the insect world, rainwater dripping into the necropolis through myriad cracks, a boulder fallen in front of Cave 10 damming up the insides with three feet of mulch, the jungle practically at its doorstep—such was the state Ajanta was in when the first European made his famous arrival at these portals on April 28, 1819. Likely led there by a local Bhil during a tiger hunt, and no doubt feeling like Indiana Jones at the Temple of Doom, he proceeded to add human vandalism to the depredations the murals had been facing. Carved with a knife across the faded chest of a Buddha on a pillar outside Cave 10 is the scrawl that has entered the ASI list of Ajanta inscriptions, marked 'intrusive': "*John Smith, 28th Cavalry*".

GOOD INTENTIONS GONE HORRIBLY WRONG

Colonial-era interventions are easy to outrage over—the hordes with their buccaneering style, the early reception of Ajanta's murals as "barbaric" and, more pertinently, the primitive restoration methods employed by those who began hewing to the opposite view. Trophy hunters tore out paintings. James Prinsep, the man who decoded Brahmi, wrote in 1836 that one Dr James Bird had "contrived to peel off four paintings...despite protestations". A 14 x 10 inch fragment from those days of loot, *Conversion of Nanda* from Cave 16, rests at the Boston Museum of Fine Arts.

But there was the other side: the exhaustive study